

EXPERIMENT – 2

Encryption – Crypto 101 using TryHackMe

Step 1: Login to Platform

Open the browser and go to TryHackMe.
Login using your account.

Step 2: Open Crypto 101 Room

Search for **Crypto 101** and click **Join Room**.

Step 3: Start Environment

Click **Start Machine / AttackBox** to launch the virtual lab.

Step 4: Perform Cryptography Tasks

(a) Base64 Encoding/Decoding

(b) Hex Conversion

(c) Caesar Cipher

Step 5: Submit Answers

Enter the decoded results in the answer boxes and complete all tasks.



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Encryption - Crypto 101

An introduction to encryption, as part of a series on crypto

45 min 140,683

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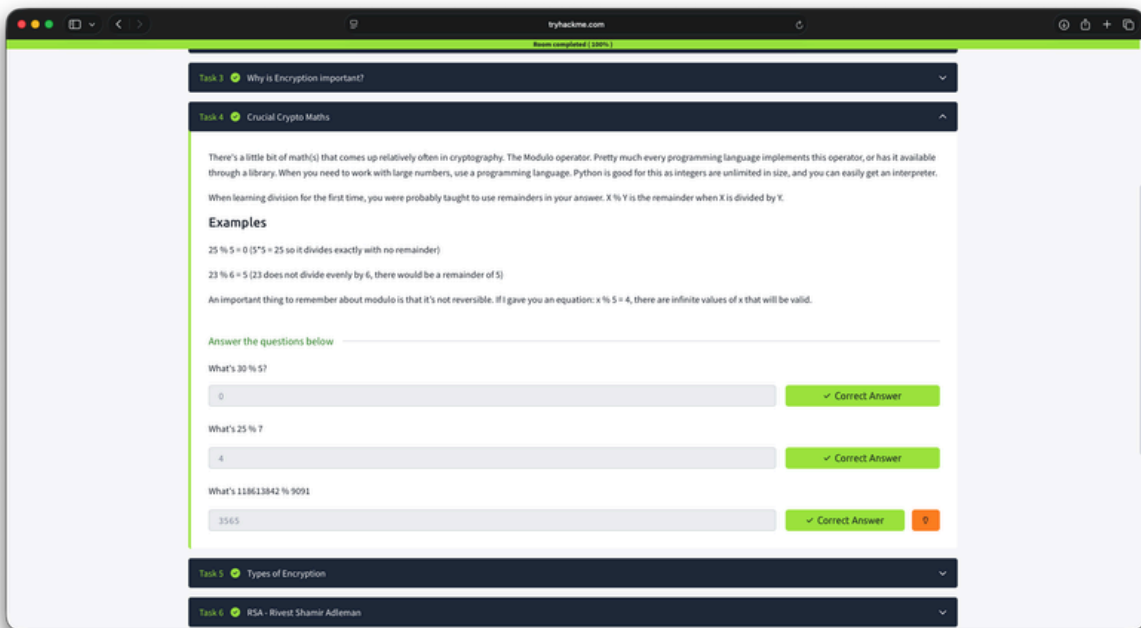
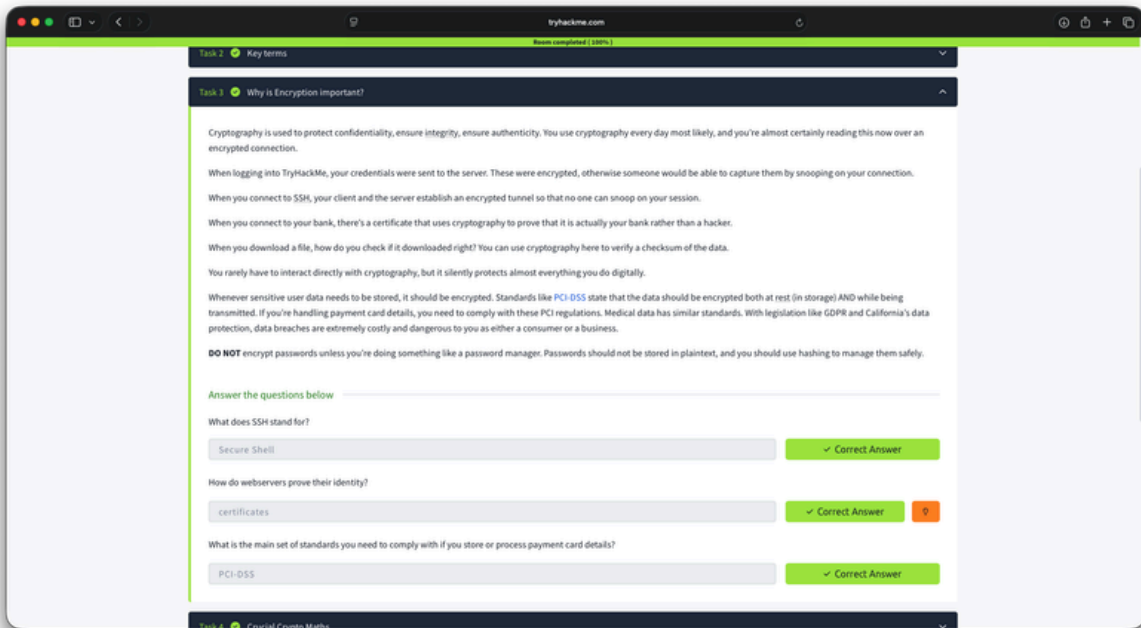
Room completed (100%)

Task 1 What will this room cover?

Task 2 Key terms

Task 3 Why is Encryption important?

Task 4 Crucial Crypto Maths



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Room completed (100%)

Task 4 Crucial Crypto Maths

Task 5 Types of Encryption

The two main categories of Encryption are symmetric and asymmetric.

Symmetric encryption uses the same key to encrypt and decrypt the data. Examples of Symmetric encryption are DES (Broken) and AES. These algorithms tend to be faster than asymmetric cryptography, and use smaller keys (128 or 256 bit keys are common for AES, DES keys are 56 bits long).

Asymmetric encryption uses a pair of keys, one to encrypt and the other in the pair to decrypt. Examples are RSA and Elliptic Curve Cryptography. Normally these keys are referred to as a public key and a private key. Data encrypted with the private key can be decrypted with the public key, and vice versa. Your private key needs to be kept private, hence the name. Asymmetric encryption tends to be slower and uses larger keys, for example RSA typically uses 2048 to 4096 bit keys.

RSA and Elliptic Curve cryptography are based around different mathematically difficult (intractable) problems, which give them their strength. More about RSA later.

Answer the questions below

Should you trust DES? Yea/Nay

Nay ✓ Correct Answer

What was the result of the attempt to make DES more secure so that it could be used for longer?

Triple DES ✓ Correct Answer

Is it ok to share your public key? Yea/Nay

Yea ✓ Correct Answer

Task 6 RSA - Rivest Shamir Adleman

Task 7 Establishing Keys Using Asymmetric Cryptography

Task 8 Digital signatures and Certificates

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Task 6 RSA - Rivest Shamir Adleman

The math(s) side

RSA is based on the mathematically difficult problem of working out the factors of a large number. It's very quick to multiply two prime numbers together, say $17 \times 23 = 391$, but it's quite difficult to work out what two prime numbers multiply together to make 14351 (113x127 for reference).

The attacking side

The maths behind RSA seems to come up relatively often in CTFs, normally requiring you to calculate variables or break some encryption based on them. The wikipedia page for RSA seems complicated at first, but will give you almost all of the information you need in order to complete challenges.

There are some excellent tools for defeating RSA challenges in CTFs, and my personal favorite is <https://github.com/Ganapati/RsaCtfTool> which has worked very well for me. I've also had some success with <https://github.com/tux/rSATool>.

The key variables that you need to know about for RSA in CTFs are p , q , m , n , e , d , and c .

" p " and " q " are large prime numbers, " n " is the product of p and q .

The public key is n and e , the private key is n and d .

" m " is used to represent the message (in plaintext) and " c " represents the ciphertext (encrypted text).

CTFs involving RSA

Crypto CTF challenges often present you with a set of these values, and you need to break the encryption and decrypt a message to retrieve the flag.

There's a lot more maths to RSA, and it gets quite complicated fairly quickly. If you want to learn the maths behind it, I recommend reading MuirlandOracle's blog post here: <https://muirlandoracle.co.uk/2020/01/25/rsa-encryption/>.

Answer the questions below

$p = 4391, q = 6659$. What is n ?

29239609 ✓ Correct Answer

I understand enough about RSA to move on, and I know where to look to learn more if I want to.

No answer needed ✓ Correct Answer

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Room completed (100%)

Task 0 RSA - Rivest Shamir Adleman

Task 1 Establishing Keys Using Asymmetric Cryptography

Task 2 Digital signatures and Certificates

A very common use of asymmetric cryptography is exchanging keys for symmetric encryption.

Asymmetric encryption tends to be slower, so for things like HTTPS symmetric encryption is better.

But the question is, how do you agree a key with the server without transmitting the key for people snooping to see?

Metaphor time

Imagine you have a secret code, and instructions for how to use the secret code. If you want to send your friend the instructions without anyone else being able to read it, what you could do is ask your friend for a lock.

Only they have the key for this lock, and we'll assume you have an indestructible box that you can lock with it.

If you send the instructions in a locked box to your friend, they can unlock it once it reaches them and read the instructions.

After that, you can communicate in the secret code without risk of people snooping.

In this metaphor, the secret code represents a symmetric encryption key, the lock represents the server's public key, and the key represents the server's private key.

You've only used asymmetric cryptography once, so it's fast, and you can now communicate privately with symmetric encryption.

The Real World

In reality, you need a little more cryptography to verify the person you're talking to is who they say they are, which is done using digital signatures and certificates. You can find a lot more detail on how HTTPS (one example where you need to exchange keys) really works from this excellent blog post. <https://robertheaton.com/2014/03/27/how-does-https-actually-work/>

Answer the questions below

I understand how keys can be established using Public Key (asymmetric) cryptography.

No answer needed

✓ Correct Answer

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Tasks completed (100%)

Task 6 RSA - Private Shared Asymmetric

Task 7 Establishing Keys Using Asymmetric Cryptography

Task 8 Digital Signatures and Certificates

What's a Digital Signature?

Digital signatures are a way to prove the authenticity of files, to prove who created or modified them. Using asymmetric cryptography, you produce a signature with your private key and it can be verified using your public key. As only you should have access to your private key, this proves you signed the file. Digital signatures and physical signatures have the same value in the UK, legally.

The simplest form of digital signature would be encrypting the document with your private key, and then if someone wanted to verify this signature they would decrypt it with your public key and check if the files match.

Certificates - Prove who you are!

Certificates are also a key use of public key cryptography, linked to digital signatures. A common place where they're used is for HTTPS. How does your web browser know that the server you're talking to is the real tryhackme.com?

The answer is certificates. The web server has a certificate that says it is the real tryhackme.com. The certificates have a chain of trust, starting with a root CA (certificate authority). Root CAs are automatically trusted by your device, OS, or browser from install. Certs below that are trusted because the Root CAs say they trust that organisation. Certificates below that are trusted because the organisation is trusted by the Root CA and so on. There are long chains of trust. Again, this blog post explains this much better than I can. <https://robertheaton.com/2014/03/27/how-does-https-actually-work/>

You can get your own HTTPS certificates for domains you own using Let's Encrypt for free. If you run a website, it's worth setting it up.

Answer the questions below

What can you use to verify that a file has not been modified and is the authentic file as the author intended?

Digital Signature

✓ Correct Answer

Task 9 SSH Authentication

Task 10 Explaining Diffie Hellman Key Exchange

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Tasks completed (100%)

Task 8 Digital Signatures and Certificates

Task 9 SSH Authentication

Task 10 Explaining Diffie Hellman Key Exchange

What is Key Exchange?

Key exchange allows 2 people/parties to establish a set of common cryptographic keys without an observer being able to get these keys. Generally, to establish common symmetric keys.

How does Diffie Hellman Key Exchange work?

Alice and Bob want to talk securely. They want to establish a common key, so they can use symmetric cryptography, but they don't want to use key exchange with asymmetric cryptography. This is where DH Key Exchange comes in.

Alice and Bob both have secrets that they generate, let's call these A and B. They also have some common material that's public, let's call this C.

We need to make some assumptions. Firstly, whenever we combine secrets/material it's impossible or very very difficult to separate. Secondly, the order that they're combined in doesn't matter.

Alice and Bob will combine their secrets with the common material, and form AC and BC. They will then send these to each other, and combine that with their secrets to form two identical keys, both ABC. Now they can use this key to communicate.

Extra Resources

An excellent video if you want a visual explanation is available here. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NmM9HA2MqG0>

DH Key Exchange is often used alongside RSA public key cryptography, to prove the identity of the person you're talking to with digital signing. This prevents someone from attacking the connection with a man-in-the-middle attack by pretending to be Bob.

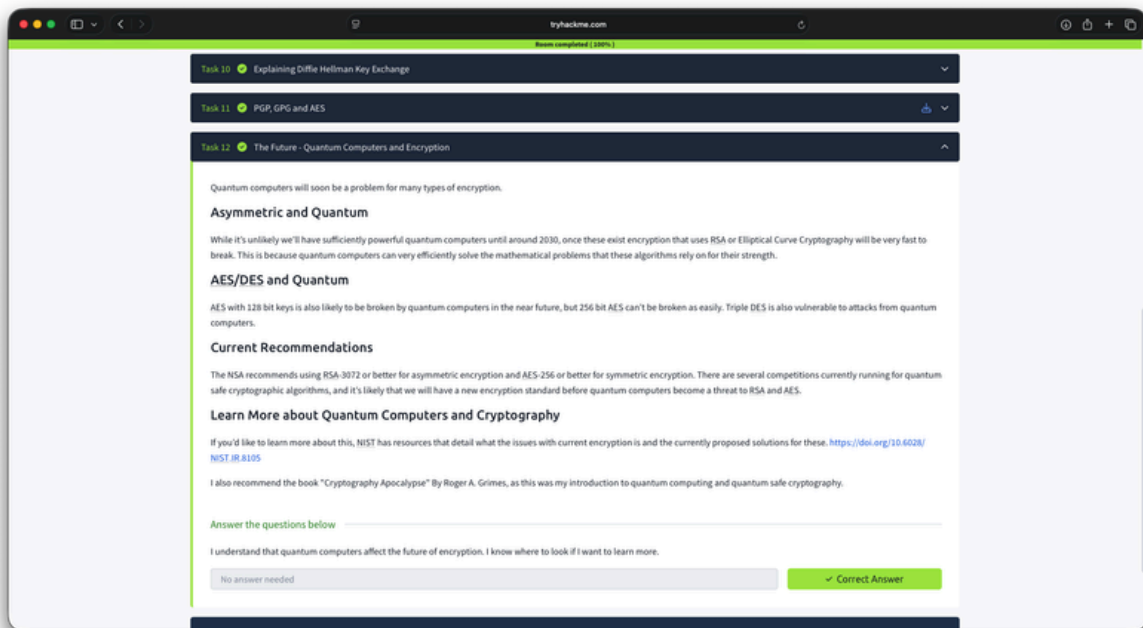
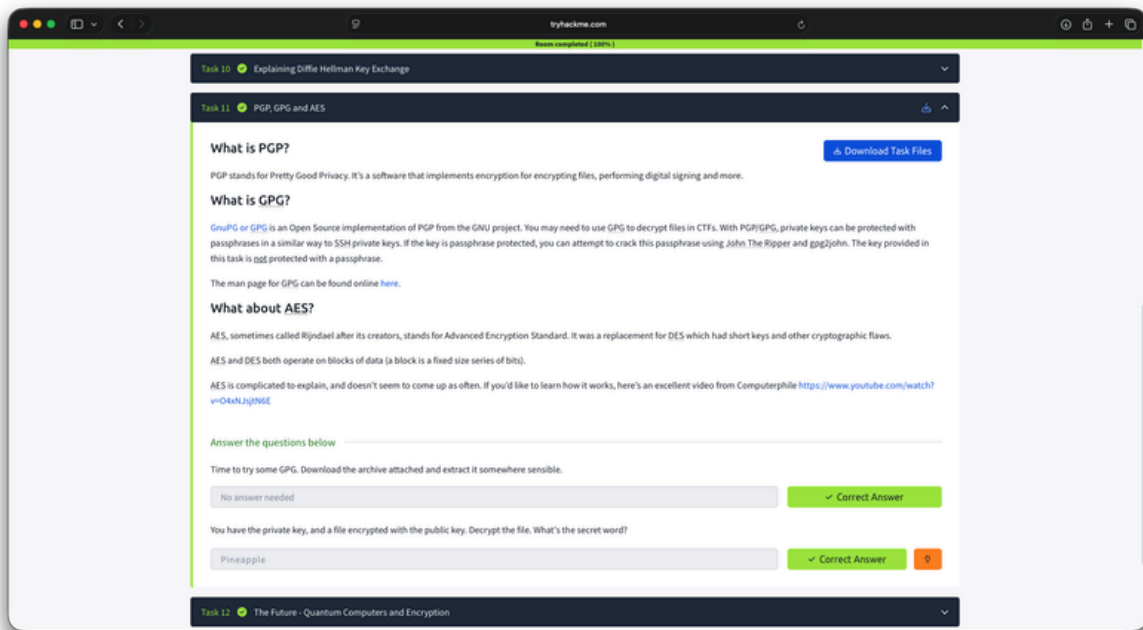
Answer the questions below

I understand how Diffie Hellman Key Exchange works at a basic level

No answer needed

✓ Correct Answer

Task 11 PGP, GPG and AES



Result

Basic cryptography concepts such as encoding, decoding, hashing, and classical ciphers were successfully performed using TryHackMe.